Nina in the Morning

By Christopher Durang

INTRODUCTION

Everyone has a story, a history that is unique. Unfortunately, in America the elderly are not a valued sector of society. For this reason many Americans are in denial of aging, the plastic surgery industry his exploded and women are perpetually turning "29." As a culture, we appreciate vintage in wine, not people; we "distress" furniture to make it look old, but pay thousands of dollars to erase the wrinkles that time bestows on our faces. It's a futile battle we are all destined to fight. Today Nina is another day older as we take a tongue-in-cheek look at aging with Nina in the Morning by Christopher Durang.

The NARRATOR is onstage. He is dressed in a tuxedo and looks elegant. As the music is finishing, NINA enters. She walks towards her chaise with great regalness, as if she's in a procession, on her way to be crowned. When the NARRATOR speaks, he is speaking her thoughts, usually. So her facial expressions change with his comments. She does not otherwise look at him or relate to him (with a couple of noted exceptions)

NARRATOR: The mist hangs heavy over the ocean today. Nina woke from an uncertain sleep and walked to the chaise in her dressing room and sat in front of the beautiful, cherished mirror. *(NINA sits on her chaise, and looks out to her mirror and gasps.)* Her facelift had fallen during the night, and her cheeks were held in place by straight pins.

NINA: *(Looking in mirror, touching her face delicately)* Oh, Lord. Oh, Lord. How dreadful. *(Enter JAMES, her child, dressed in short pants and a white shirt. He looks like a well-dressed prep-school boy)*

JAMES: Good morning, mother.

NINA: Don't kiss mommy today, her face is precarious.

JAMES: I don't want to kiss you anyway. I hate you.

NINA: Please don't upset me, James. My plastic surgeon is in Aruba.

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JAMES: What's this pin for? *(Reaches for her face, pulls out a pin.)*

NINA: James, stop that. Stop it. Foote! Foote! Come quickly, James is at my face again.

NARRATOR: But James kept reaching for Nina's face, over and over.

NINA: Stop it, you unruly child. *(JAMES keeps trying to pull pins out of her face. NINA keeps trying to protect her face. All the pin business is mimed. FOOTE, the family manservant, enters. Dignified and in a tuxedo.)*

FOOTE: You called, Madame?

NARRATOR: Foote, seeing Nina's predicament with her son, pulled James away from her, pushed him to the ground and sat on him. *(FOOTE pulls JAMES away, pushes him on the ground and sits on him.)*

NINA: Gently, Foote, gently.

JAMES: *(Struggling with FOOTE.)* I hate you, mother, I hate you.

NARRATOR: Foote took out a hypodermic from his jacket pocket, and gave the misbehaving child a shot.

JAMES I hate you. I'm sleepy. *(Passes out.)*

FOOTE: Will that be all, Madame?

NARRATOR: Foote was the family manservant, and often gave the children general anesthesia whenever they became unruly. Foote had once been a dentist.

NINA: Thank you, Foote. James was pulling pins out again. I must have done something wrong raising them. I thought I often smiled. I wonder if they wanted anything else.

FOOTE: Do you wish me to remove any teeth while he's out?

NINA: No, no. Leave his teeth alone, Foote. I just want quiet for a while. Look at how peaceful James is, curled on the floor. I always liked my children best when they were unconscious.

FOOTE: If Madame needs me further, just call.

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NINA: Thank you, Foote. You're a jewel. *(FOOTE exits.)*

NARRATOR: Foote withdrew, leaving Nina with her thoughts. She thought about her face. She thought about James. Psychotherapy had been no help for James except perhaps in helping him to express his anger more freely, and how useful had that been.

NINA: *(Sort of to herself.)* Not very.

NARRATOR: Nina's hands shook as she lifted a coffee cup to her face. Her perceptions were off, and she poured hot liquid down the left side of her face. She put cream and sugar on her face, stirred it and then rang the bell for Foote. *(NINA mimes the actions the NARRATOR says above while, or shortly after, he says them. She does all the gestures without emotion. She feels the heat of the coffee and the mess of the liquids after she has done all of them. She makes a face of pain, and confusion, then rings the bell.)*

NINA: Foote, I need you. Bring a wet cloth. I'm sticky.

NARRATOR: Foote brought a basin of warm water and a roll of gauze and sponged her gingerly. *(FOOTE enters and starts to pat NINA's face lightly with the cloth.)*

NINA: Do you think I'm beautiful, Foote?

FOOTE: You once were very striking, Madame.

NINA: Yes, but now, what do you think of me now?

FOOTE: *(Looks at her.)* You have quite a nasty burn on your face, Madame. Would you care for a shot of novocaine?

NINA: Go away, Foote. I want to think.

NARRATOR: And again, Foote withdrew, dragging James after him. Nina racked her brain, trying to remember what she wanted to think. The colors of her wall were beige. She had wanted burnt orange, but the designer had run through the house screaming "Beige! Beige!" and they finally had to give him his way.

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NINA: *(Out, to the imagined designer.)* I wanted burnt orange, but you have given me beige.

NARRATOR: Later the designer turned against her too, like her son James. No, no, Nina wanted pleasant thoughts, nice things. Flowers, butterflies . . .

NINA: *(Hopefully.)* Little duckies.

NARRATOR: The Little Prince by Saint-Exupéry. That was a nauseating little book, she had never finished it. Some monk gave it to her when her car had been stopped at a traffic light.

NINA: Foote, if any Jehovah's Witnesses come today, show them in, will you?

NARRATOR: But no Jehovah's Witnesses came. And Nina found she had to fill the time with thinking and reminiscing. Nina had once been beautiful.

NINA: I am very beautiful.

NARRATOR: Men would stop on the street to stare at her. She caused traffic accidents. Jealous women would rush up to her in their homeliness and try to kill her.

NINA: Homely women were always trying to shoot me. It was flattering really.

NARRATOR: Everywhere she went, her eyes would anxiously seek out the mirrors. Sometimes she would bring her own mirrors with her.

NINA: Put this up, would you?

NARRATOR: Nina would say, lugging a large mirror, and few could deny her. Her love affairs were unpredictable and random. Sometimes it would be royalty, other times it would be the men from Con Edison. *(The NARRATOR turns his back, pretending to look at a power box. He is now the CON EDISON MAN. NINA comes up to him, stands close and seductive.)*

NINA: I don't really know where the power box is, I'm afraid. Would you care to lie down? *(The NARRATOR reverts to his narrator role, and addresses the audience again.)*

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NARRATOR: Sometimes when she was especially lonely, she would try to seduce her children.

NINA: Don't you find mommy especially attractive today?

NARRATOR: She would ask James . . . and Robert . . . and occasionally poor La-La.

LA-LA: *(Happily and monotonously singing to herself.)* La-la-la-la-la, la-la-la-la, la, la, la, la . . .

NARRATOR: La-La was retarded, and Nina hated her.

NINA: La-La! Pay attention! *(LA-LA turns away, opens up her lunch box and starts looking through it happily.)*

LA-LA: La-la-la-la-la, la-la-la . . .

NINA: Uhhhh. You're willfully retarded.

NARRATOR: Nina would shout this at La-La, and then hit her. But Nina mustn't think of the past now. The present was what held promise. Her plastic surgeon was due back in several days. *(NINA rings the bell.)*

NINA: *(Grandly.)* Foote, I want a cruller!

NARRATOR: She heard what she presumed were Foote's footsteps, but they belonged to her second son, Robert, who fired two shots, one of which grazed her shoulder. *(Enter ROBERT, dressed the same as JAMES but with the addition of the glasses. He shoots a pistol twice at his mother. On the second shot, NINA moves her shoulder as if hit.)*

ROBERT: I hate you, mother!

NARRATOR: Then he ran into the garden. *(ROBERT runs off. NINA holds her shoulder and rings the bell again.)*

NINA: Foote, bring the gauze again, please. My shoulder is bleeding. Foote! Foote!

NARRATOR: James's father had been a tax lawyer, but Robert's father had been one of twenty men; and La-La's father had been one of fifty-six men that busy summer she had the beach house painted. After a brief burst of self-

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judgment, she searched the thesaurus for alternatives to the word "promiscuity."

NINA: *(Miming looking in a dictionary.)* Synonyms include "debauchery." "Salacity." And "lubricity." "Lubricity." "Loooo-bricity." "Looooo-briiiiiiii-ci-teeeeeeeeeee.

NARRATOR: Nina liked the sound of "lubricity" and that summer she would climb up the ladders and whisper the word into the house-painters' ears. *(The NARRATOR finds himself near NINA. She stands and seductively whispers in his ear, as if he's the house painter.)*

NINA: *(Whispering into his ear.)* Lubricity. *(Enter FOOTE with some more gauze.)*

FOOTE: Has Madame been shot?

NINA: Yes, Foote. Robert said something to me, something mean, and then he shot me. What took you so long?

FOOTE: I'm sorry, Madame. I was giving La-La a hypodermic shot to calm her down. She was complaining about something and acting retarded, and now she's quiet and good as a lamb.

NINA: Go away, Foote.

FOOTE: Yes, Madame.

NINA: Oh my life, my life, my life. What has become of my life? *(Looks in the mirror anew.)* And what has become of my face? Oh my. Pins are for curtains, not for faces.

NARRATOR: Nina stared at herself in the mirror and tried to decide whether or not to kill herself. She stared a long while. She didn't look well. Slowly she took the pins out of her face. *(NINA mimes taking pins out. Then she pulls her cheeks downward, and stares tragically at herself in the mirror.)*

NARRATOR: Her cheeks drooped downward, and her eyes filled with tears. Of course, when the doctor returned from Aruba, he'd make Nina look substantially

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better. And she didn't know how to kill herself, unless one of her children shot her.

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AWARDS

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